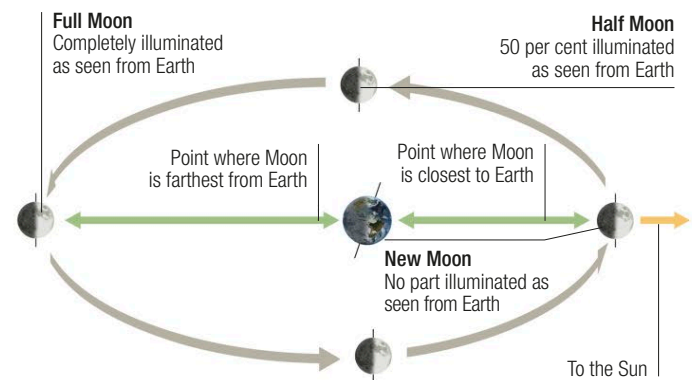




Montes Caucasus

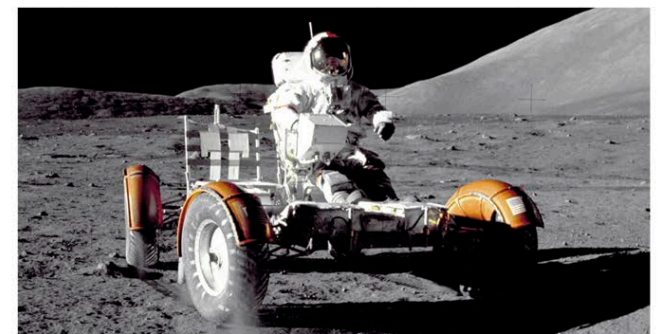
Earth's satellite

The Moon is responsible for the tides in Earth's seas: it pulls water toward it, thereby raising a bulge on one side of the planet. Another bulge forms on the opposite side of the planet, where the Moon's gravity is weakest. The Moon's presence may also have stabilized Earth's spin axis, which has helped life develop here.



△ Phases of the Moon

The Moon shows phases during its orbit around the Earth, as the amount of sunlit ground seen from Earth varies. The orbit isn't circular since the distance between Earth and the Moon varies from 225,300 to 251,900 miles (362,600 to 405,400 km).



△ Astronauts on the Moon

Twelve astronauts walked on the Moon between 1969 and 1972, during six Apollo missions. Their work, and the study of the rocks and soil that they returned to Earth, transformed lunar science.

This image, taken between the Earth and the Sun, shows our planet almost fully illuminated

Only a small amount of the Moon's far side is covered in maria



<△ Near side of the Moon

It takes the Moon the same amount of time to spin on its own axis as it takes for it to orbit Earth. Known as synchronous rotation, it means that the side of the Moon shown here is always facing Earth.

△ Earth and Moon still

The differences between the surfaces of our planet and the Moon are obvious in this image. The grayish lunar surface reflects only 12 percent of the light falling on it, whilst the colorful Earth reflects around 30 percent. The Moon's far side, never seen from Earth, is visible here.